‘You should call the police’: Social support in crime victim reporting

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Outline

This talk in a nutshell

The problem

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This talk in a nutshell

- Victims of crime not always notify the police
- This distorts the enforcer's view of crime and, in some scenarios, precludes victims from receiving help
- One theoretical factor of reporting that is understudied is **the ability to talk the incident through with friends or family**
- I attempt to identify the factor's effect using data from RCVS 2024
- Regression results back up expectations, but a plausible backdoor remains
- IV to the rescue, but the instrument is too weak

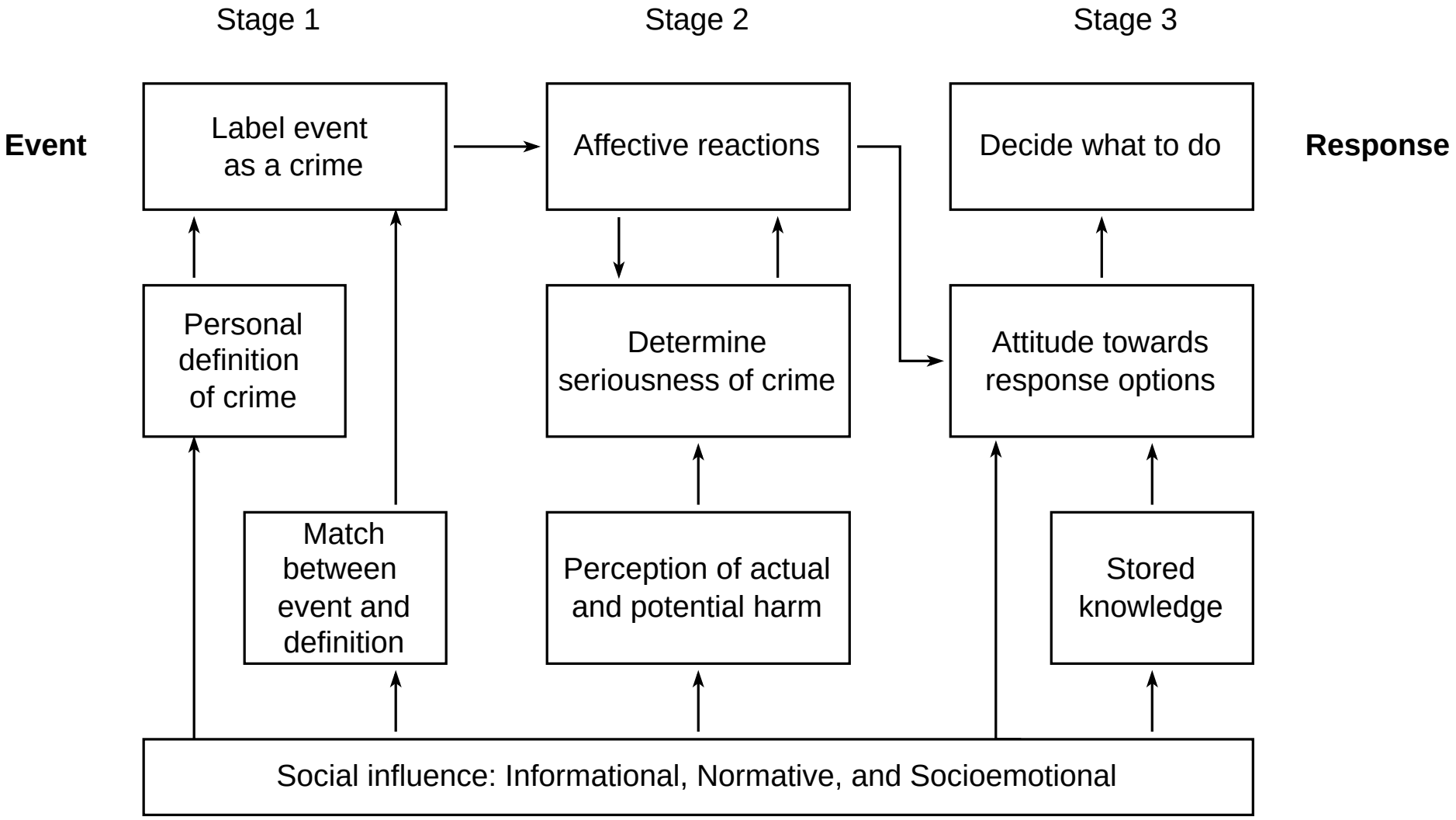
Why is non-reporting a problem?

- Non-reporting distorts the enforcer's view of crime rates and structure which precludes optimal resource allocation for crime prevention.
- In a broader sense, under-reporting distorts understanding of how crime impacts individuals, communities and neighborhoods. This has implications both for administration and legislation.
- In some situations, e.g. intimate partner violence, early intervention from authority can prevent progressively heavier damage – this can not happen if the police is not notified.

Theoretical models of crime reporting

- Macrosociological: **black1976behavior** posited that mobilization of law can be explained by stratification, morphology, culture, organization, and social control.
- Rational choice: The main determinants of decision to notify the police relate to gravity of incident and perceived costs and benefits of reporting (**gottfredson1979study**; **skogan1984reporting**; **tarling2010reporting**).
  - This view has been criticized on the grounds that a victim never has full information and is usually in a condition that compromises his or hers ability for calculation of costs and benefits (**gottfredson1987decision**).
- Attitudes: This view focuses on perception of police legitimacy and ability, as well as on gender roles and victim blaming (**tyler2003procedural**; **orcutt1988sex**).
- Social influence: decision making is a complex process which is affected by a victim's social context (**greenberg2012after**).

Greenberg and Ruback's victim decision making model



Adapted from **greenberg2012after**

Data: RCVS

Russian Crime Victimization Survey (RCVS)
(**sereb2022dynamics**)

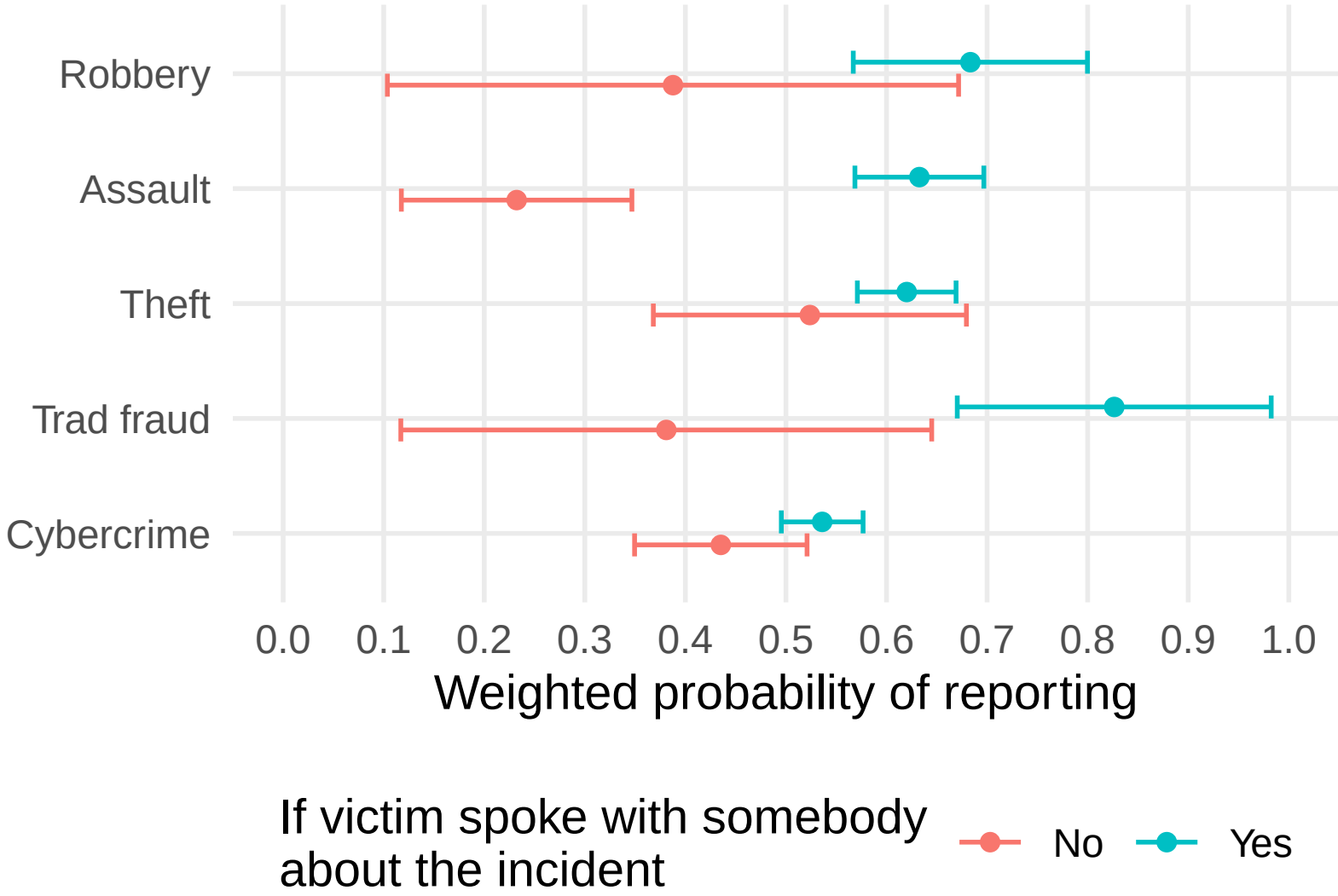
- a regular and nationally representative victimization survey,
- targets citizens 18+ years old,
- three waves so far: 2018, 2021, 2024,
- performed as computer assisted telephone interview (CATI) using a randomly generated set of telephone numbers (RDD),
- includes calibration weights obtained via raking procedure.

Data: 2024 victimization

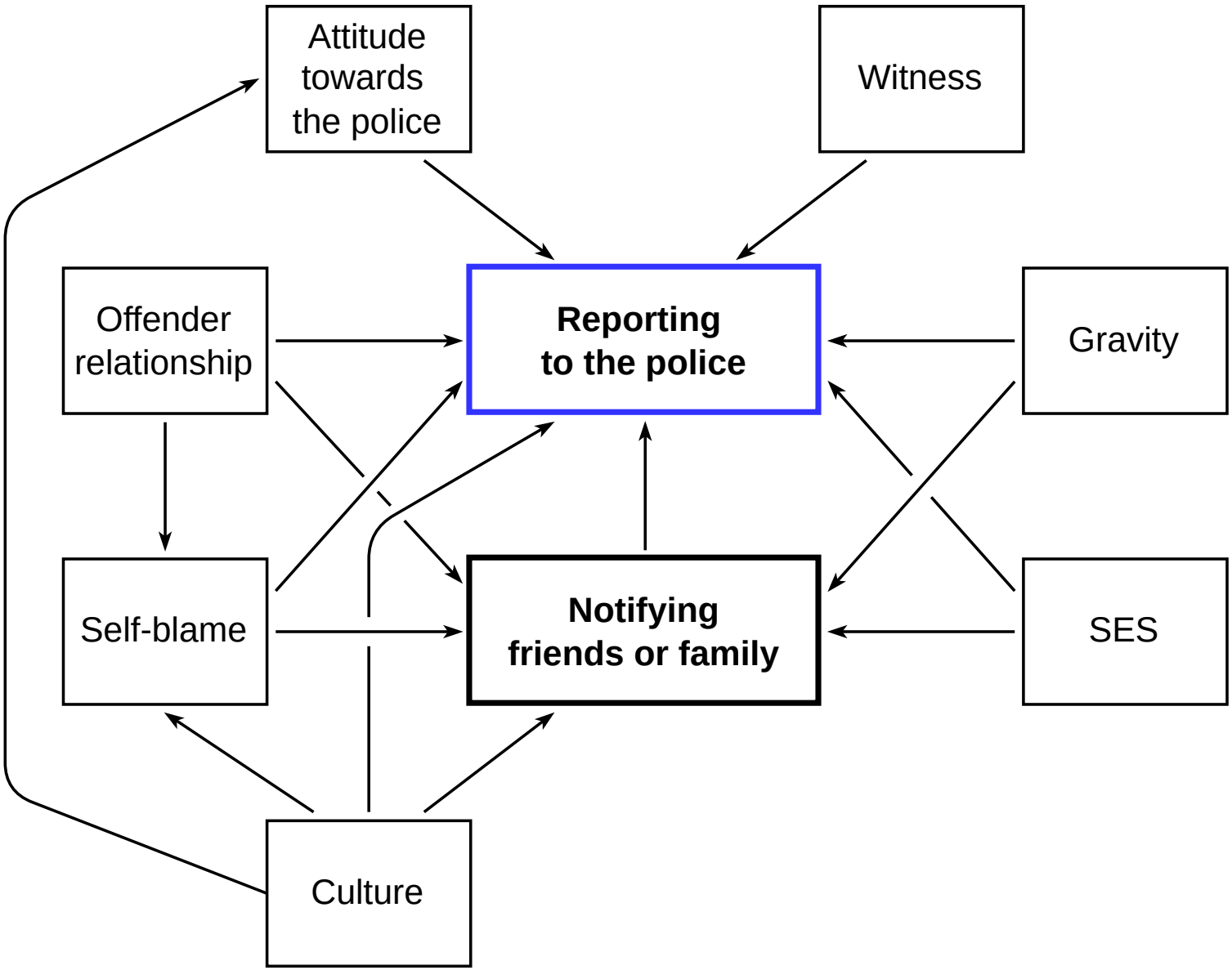
- The 2024 survey interviewed 11 323 people, with response rate at 0.15–0.91%.
- 2 685 respondents said they had been victimized in some way in the past year.
- Only 44% of them notified the police.

Gender	Reported	Cybercrime	Trad fraud	Theft	Assault	Robbery
Female	0	169	2	80	36	4
	1	198	10	127	64	17
Male	0	184	6	85	91	27
	1	184	17	134	94	38

Raw conditional means on 2024 data



Identification strategy: Model



Identification strategy: Logistic regression

$$P(Reported_i | ToldSomeone = ToldSomeone_i, X_j = x_{ij}) = \sigma(\beta_0 + \beta_1 ToldSomeone_i + \sum_{1}^{j} \beta_j X_{ij}) \quad (1)$$

where

- *Reported* is unity when a victim notified the police and zero otherwise,
- *ToldSomeone* indicates talking with friends or family about the incident,
- and X is a set of j controls which includes measures of financial and emotional damage, reported self-blame, victim's SES, attitude towards police, settlement size type and federal district.

In case of violent crimes X also includes level of physical damage, incident features, and type of offender-victim relationship.

▸ List of all variables

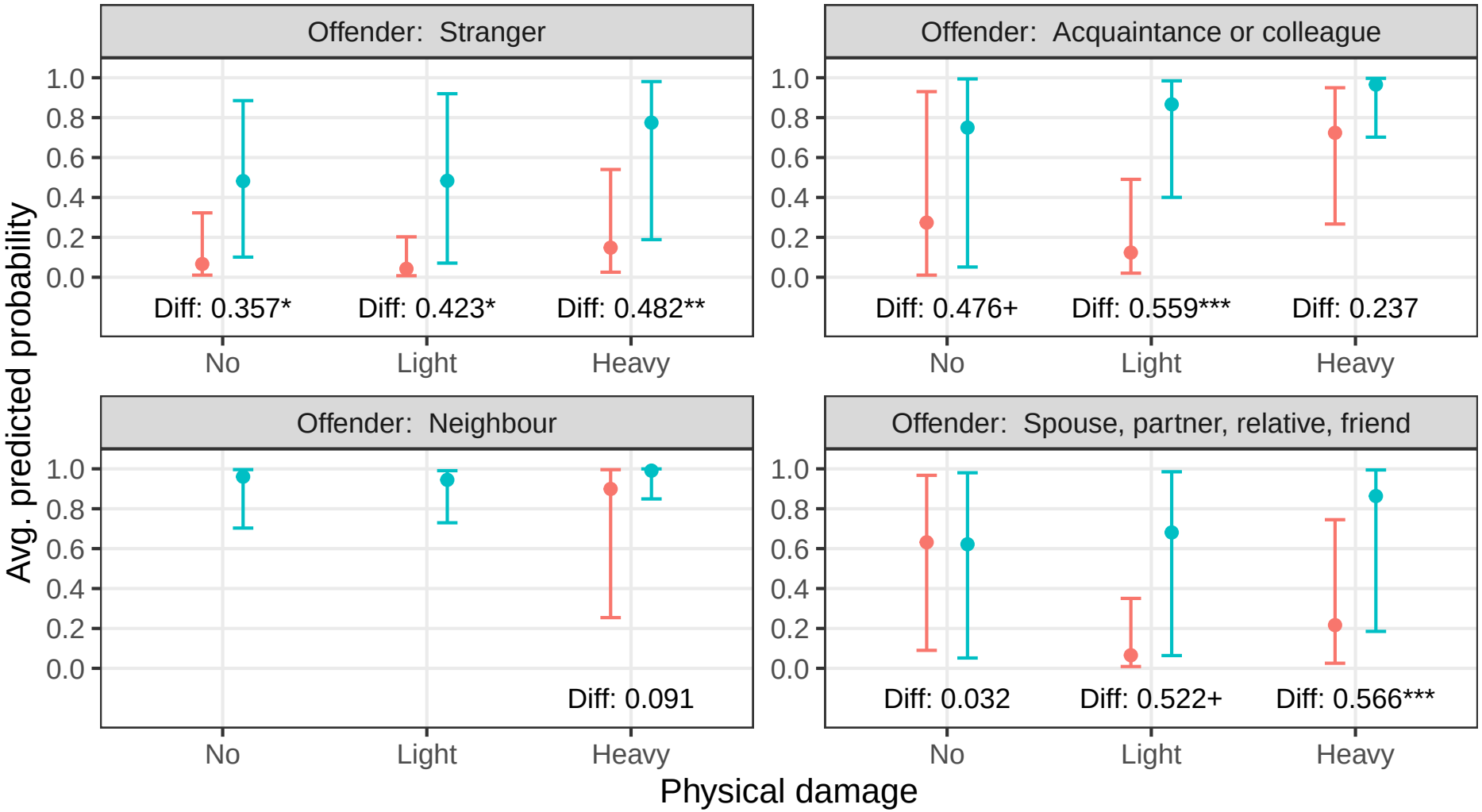
Logistic regression result (abridged)

Dep. var.: Victim notified the police	Theft	Cybercrime	All property	Assault	All violent
Social factors					
Told someone: Yes	1.046 (0.565)	1.714 (0.465)+	1.625 (0.473)	13.057 (9.309)**	12.307 (8.365)**
Self-blame: Yes	0.674 (0.180)	0.671 (0.150)	0.621 (0.096)*	0.667 (0.320)	0.587 (0.278)
Has partner: Yes	0.915 (0.221)	0.929 (0.166)	0.946 (0.094)	1.076 (0.460)	1.133 (0.352)
Offender relationship					
Acquaintance or colleague				5.012 (2.984)*	4.833 (2.659)*
Neighbour				7.070 (4.861)*	6.815 (3.067)**
Spouse, partner, relative, friend				1.378 (0.711)	1.727 (0.834)
Perceived harm					
Financial					
(1, 10] thnd rub.	0.962 (0.347)	2.014 (0.930)	1.487 (0.583)	2.484 (1.793)	2.121 (1.535)
(10, 50] thnd rub.	2.389 (0.938)+	3.351 (1.153)**	2.692 (0.795)**	1.347 (1.155)	2.114 (1.187)
(50, Inf] thnd rub.	3.908 (1.258)**	8.962 (2.664)***	5.868 (1.588)***	2.195 (2.144)	2.642 (1.408)+
Physical					
Light				0.868 (0.546)	0.901 (0.406)
Heavy				2.544 (1.732)	2.472 (1.267)
Emotional					
Medium	2.386 (1.040)+	1.075 (0.313)	1.280 (0.354)	0.338 (0.245)	0.375 (0.263)
Heavy	3.499 (1.435)*	2.261 (0.736)*	2.443 (0.621)**	0.813 (0.403)	1.053 (0.519)
Num. obs.	405	703	1143	260	304
Pseudo R^2 Within	0.135	0.136	0.120	0.264	0.272
RMSE	0.44	0.45	0.45	0.41	0.41
Std.Errors	Fed. district	Fed. district	Fed. district	Fed. district	Fed. district
Fixed effects: Fed. district	X	X	X	X	X

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

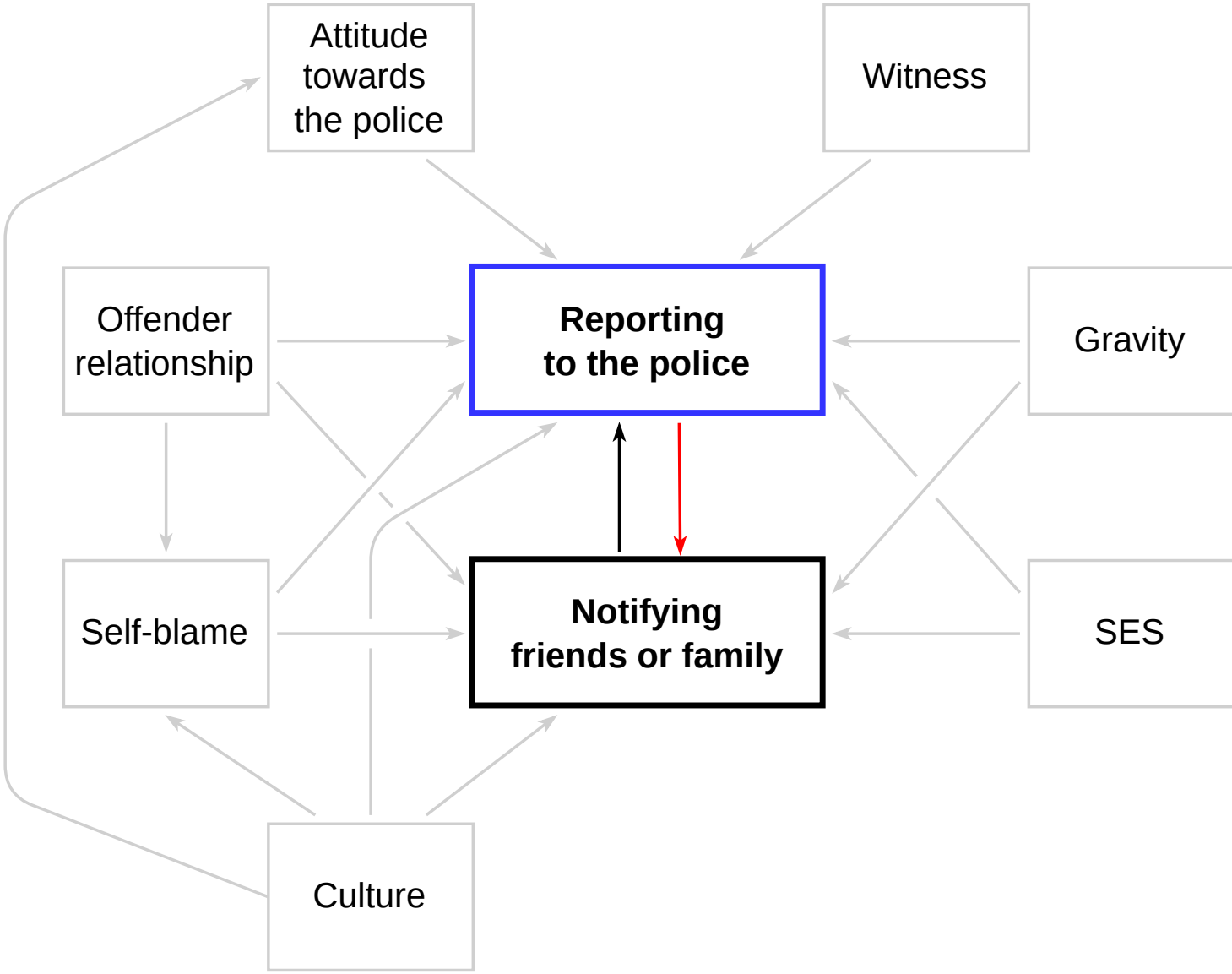
Coefficients are exponentiated. Only variables of interest are shown.

Avg. predicted prob. of reporting a violent victimization

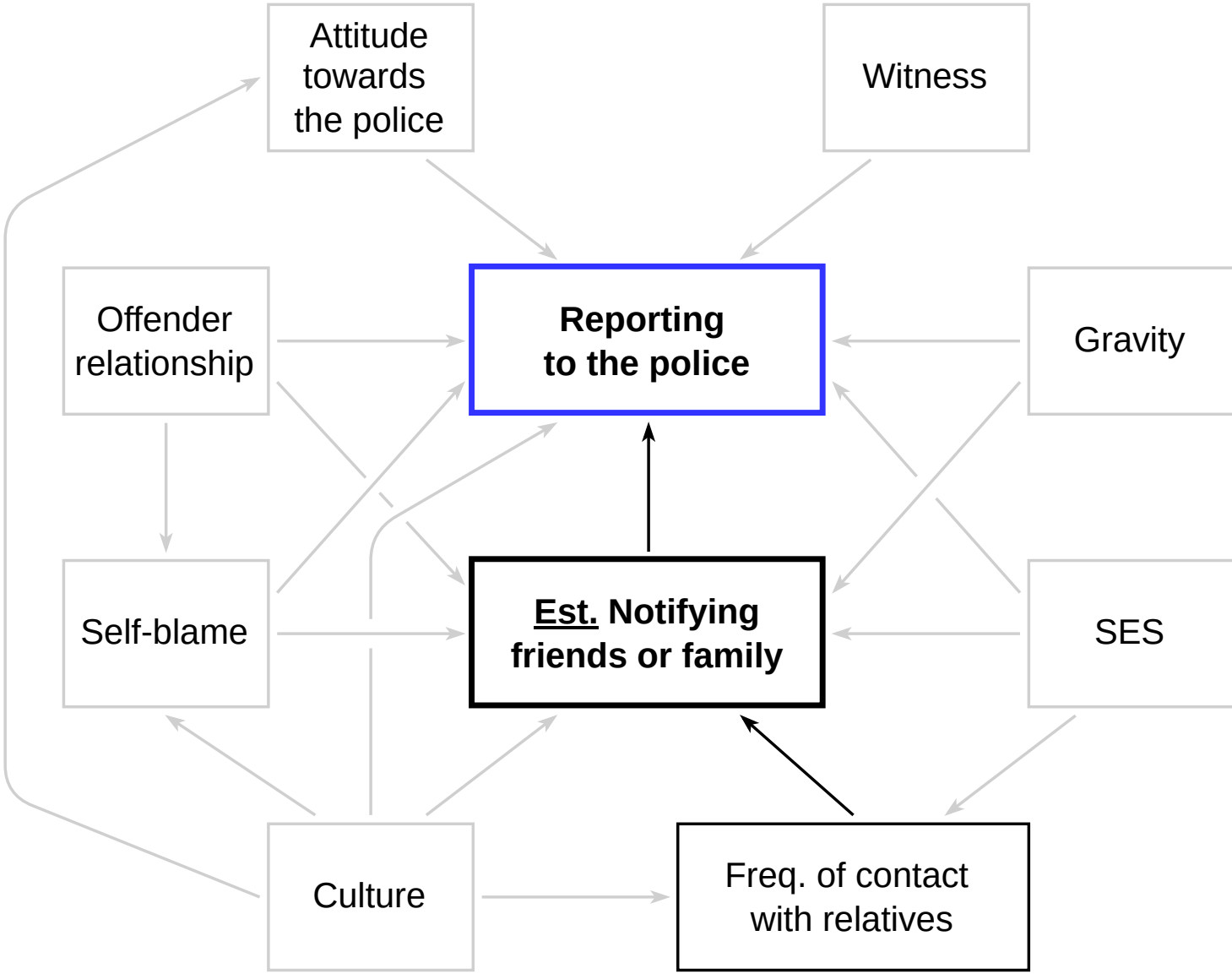


+ p < 0.1$, * p < 0.05$, ** p < 0.01$, *** p < 0.001

Identification strategy: the plausible backdoor



Robustness test: IV regression with 2SLS



Robustness test: IV regression with 2SLS

I assume that frequency of contact with relatives (*ContactRelativesFreq*)

- can explain some variation in *ToldSomeone*,
- can not have direct effect on *Reported*,

and therefore may be a suitable instrument in a two-stage least squares (2SLS) regression.

First stage:

$$ToldSomeone_i = \gamma_0 + \gamma_1 ContactRelativesFreq_i + \gamma_j \sum_1^j X_{ij} + \upsilon_i \quad (2)$$

Second stage:

$$Reported_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \widehat{ToldSomeone_i} + \beta_j \sum_1^j X_{ij} + \epsilon_i \quad (3)$$

Robustness test: Results

	Theft	Cybercrime	All property	Assault	All violent
$\widehat{ToldSomeone}$: Yes	−0.732 (0.837)	0.202 (1.710)	−0.842 (0.720)	0.113 (0.311)	0.130 (0.348)
Num.Obs.	405	703	1143	260	304
1st stage F-statistic	4.296 (p:0.014)	0.453 (p:0.635)	1.928 (p:0.146)	6.587 (p:0.002)	6.389 (p:0.002)
R2 Within	−0.028	0.165	−0.293	0.305	0.308
RMSE	0.49	0.45	0.56	0.42	0.41
Std.Errors	by: Fed. district	by: Fed. district	by: Fed. district	by: Fed. district	by: Fed. district
FE: Fed. district	X	X	X	X	X

$+$ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Alas, the instrument proved to be too weak.

Conclusion

- Discussion of victimization with friends or family is the strongest predictor of reporting violent crime to the police — after controlling for gravity of crime and other possible confounders.
- The effect is especially pronounced when offender is closely related to the victim.
- However, identification of the effect may be compromised: it is plausible that the effect is driven by victims who *first* notified the police and *then* told someone about the whole thing.
- I attempted to rule out endogeneity using frequency of contact with relatives as an instrument for probability of turning to them in case of victimization, but to no avail.
- Possible paths to defend the effect: stronger instrument, more data, changes to questionary, **your suggestions**.

List of all variables

Back

Crime gravity

- Financial damage level
- Physical damage level
- Emotional damage level

Incident features

- Victim has witness
- Victim resisted
- Offender had weapon

Victim's SES

- Gender
- Age group
- Has partner
- Income level
- Employment
- Education

Context

- Federal district
  (separate levels for MSK, SPB)
- Settlement size type

Social

- Offender relationship level
- Told someone
- Contact with relatives freq.
- Self-blame

Attitude

- Trust in police (binary)
- Victim knows some police
- Victim has crime record